

Chapter 145 - Secret

Ning Fuyi turned back to exchange a glance with Liu Wenzhu, stuffing the note into her hand and mouthing: "Who?"

Liu Wenzhu shook her head, then said uncertainly: "Hua Feihua?"

In all of Flying Flower Sect, the only person who might seek help from the two of them, besides Hua Feihua, would probably be no one else.

However, just as she finished speaking, they heard a series of hurried footsteps. The disciple who had delivered the message earlier walked back quickly, apologizing profusely: "You two have waited long. The Sect Master was feeling unwell and has only just awakened."

"Please follow me," he bowed.

Ning Fuyi had already destroyed both the note and the snake the moment he appeared. She nodded and said: "Lead the way."

Liu Wenzhu tugged at her sleeve from behind, and Ning Fuyi glanced at her to indicate there was no need to worry.

The disciple led the two of them through corridors and gaps between buildings. Flying Flower Sect's layout was extremely dense, making the entire journey feel like threading through a thick forest. Only when they reached the depths did the surroundings become more spacious.

The two walked across a bridge made of some unknown material when Ning Fuyi suddenly slapped her palm, saying anxiously: "Oh no, I left the pills I brought for Sect Master Hua back where we were just now!"

The disciple leading them turned around and scratched his head: "Ah... I'll send someone to retrieve them right away..."

"No." Ning Fuyi shook her head decisively. "Those pills were specially commissioned for cultivators and have remarkable effects."

"But the Sect Master is waiting..." the disciple said with difficulty.

"I'll go get them," Liu Wenzhu, quick-witted, suddenly spoke up. She smiled at the disciple: "Just tell me where your Sect Master is, and I'll go there myself afterward."

"It's not far," the disciple said hurriedly, turning to point at a building with a golden roof. "It's right there."

"Then you go retrieve them, so we don't breach etiquette," Ning Fuyi smiled.

Watching Liu Wenzhu's figure disappear into the distance, she casually gestured for the disciple to continue leading the way, and they soon entered the building.

The interior décor was entirely black, with only a moon-like luminous pearl embedded in the ceiling, casting gentle light. The ceiling was also adorned with many tiny glittering gems, resembling stars accompanying the moon.

If one looked carefully, they would notice the luminous pearl wasn't stationary but slowly rotating.

Hua Hong sat wrapped in a sable fur cloak in the center of the hall, the gray-brown cloak covering him tightly. Even his face was covered with a handkerchief, concealing his sickly appearance.

He coughed weakly twice before speaking: "So it's the Hall Master of Treacherous Fear Hall. My apologies for the poor reception. May I ask what brings you to see me?"

Ning Fuyi's gaze swept him from head to toe before she smiled: "Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate heard that Sect Master Hua has been bedridden with illness for some time, so they asked me to come and visit. Now with the Limitless Ghost Fire stirring up the mortal realm, and Sect Master Hua falling ill at such a time, you must be even more overwhelmed."

How could Hua Hong not hear the barbs in her words? Yet he couldn't speak plainly, only smiled: "Thank you for your concern. My constitution has always been rather weak - catching colds is common."

"Oh." Ning Fuyi's voice rose and fell, then she changed the subject: "However, there's another matter. They say Flying Flower Sect is most skilled with puppets. Now with calamity imminent, only puppets can resist the ghost fire to some degree."

"Therefore, Elder Pingyao wishes to convey a message - to borrow Flying Flower Sect's iron-armored puppets."

"That can be arranged." Hua Hong smiled and waved to summon the disciple: "Someone, bring out the two remaining puppets from the storage and give them to the Hall Master."

"Two?" Before the disciple could respond, Ning Fuyi interjected: "If I remember correctly, Flying Flower Sect has an army of several thousand puppets."

The smile on Hua Hong's face paused for a moment, then he naturally pulled his cloak tighter and laughed in surprise: "The thousands of puppets are Flying Flower Sect's lifeline. Does Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate mean for Flying Flower Sect to lend all our forces to others, then use human flesh to resist natural disasters?"

"When did I ever mention borrowing them all?" Ning Fuyi laughed lightly. "Moreover, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate borrowing puppets isn't for selfish gain, but for what's needed to jointly attack Penglai¹ with other sects."

"Sect Master Hua, as a member of the immortal sects, is unwilling to take the lead, but merely lending some inanimate objects shouldn't be excessive, should it?"

"Or is the Sect Master so cowardly and afraid of death that he's just waiting to hide behind everyone else and reap the benefits?" Ning Fuyi said with her hands behind her back.

As soon as she finished speaking, Hua Hong's face, which still had some color, immediately turned deathly pale.

"Ning Fuyi, don't speak so wildly," Hua Hong said in a deep voice. "Don't forget your own identity. Your lies may fool other immortal sects, but they can't fool me. I truly don't know what kind of enchantment you've cast to make my son willing to risk family law to help you maintain your deception!"

Ning Fuyi sneered and shook her head without changing expression.

"Now with the battle against Penglai imminent, do you think anyone still cares whether I'm demon or immortal, Sect Master Hua?" Ning Fuyi no longer held back. "You talk constantly about eliminating demons, yet when faced with true evil, you only care about protecting yourself."

"You're nothing but a bully who picks on the weak and fears the strong - truly hypocritical," Ning Fuyi scolded with satisfaction.

Hua Hong was both furious and stung by her accurate assessment. Unable to deploy his flowery rhetoric, he was so angry his hands nearly cracked the chair beneath him.

While tensions ran high here, the situation was equally thrilling elsewhere.

Liu Wenzhu concealed her presence to avoid patrolling disciples, winding around until she found the eastern corridor mentioned in the note. This was a gloomy corridor with no light on any side, only faint illumination seeping through carved patterns.

Liu Wenzhu crept in, measuring the distance with her steps before stopping to knock on the wall.

"There's no door here," Liu Wenzhu muttered, then pressed against the wall to feel carefully. Only then did she detect four cracks barely visible to the naked eye, roughly in the shape of a door.

It was actually a hidden chamber. Liu Wenzhu couldn't find a mechanism anywhere, and fearing patrolling disciples might come, she gritted her teeth and pushed with force.

Though she had already restrained her strength, she still pushed the entire bronze door outward, then quickly reached out to catch it, preventing it from crashing to the ground.

The door weighed several dozen jun², but in Liu Wenzhu's hands it was like a hollow wooden board, carefully fitted back into the wall.

She was now standing inside the door. She waved her hand to conjure a flame, illuminating the interior.

Inside was empty, without tables, chairs, or benches - it looked like a prison, or perhaps it truly was one. Liu Wenzhu carefully walked deeper into the chamber. When she saw everything clearly, she gasped.

At the far end stood four mysterious iron pillars, each topped with a steel ball made of refined steel. Accompanied by clicking sounds, they emitted silver light.

Those rays of light wove together thread by thread into a translucent cocoon floating in mid-air, with a person trapped inside, their appearance blurred and unclear.

Even though she couldn't see the face clearly, Liu Wenzhu recognized the person at first glance - it was Young Sect Master Hua Feihua. The upper half of his body was covered with wounds, while the lower half was bound by "silk threads," making it impossible to see the extent of his injuries.

"Hua Feihua!" Liu Wenzhu quickly formed hand seals, conjuring roaring flames from her palms, attempting to burn away the "cocoon."

However, those four steel balls possessed some mysterious power, rapidly absorbing the immortal force from her palms. The flames extinguished before they could even touch the "cocoon."

"It won't work. This thing is called the Four Direction Stone, specifically designed to suppress immortals. Ordinary immortal force cannot affect it!" Hua Feihua's weak voice came through the "cocoon," becoming even more faint.

"Why are you alone?" Hua Feihua asked.

Liu Wenzhu was racking her brains trying to think of a solution, answering hurriedly: "We saw your message. Ning Fuyi went to distract Sect Master Hua, so I came alone."

"Why were you imprisoned here?" Liu Wenzhu tried to set fires again, but the flames still quickly died out, making her so anxious that her hair bun became askew.

"It's a long story," Hua Feihua smiled bitterly. "Simply put, it's because I helped Ning Fuyi in Dianxing³ Town, plus other matters, which enraged my father."

"No matter how enraged, he shouldn't be so heartless!" Liu Wenzhu was very puzzled, yet the Four Direction Stone before her could not be shaken no matter what.

Finally Hua Feihua spoke: "Forget it. Your cultivation level probably can't break this. You should leave quickly. If you encounter my father's people, be careful not to get into trouble."

Liu Wenzhu was exhausted and panting, forced to stop, but she didn't leave. Instead, she suddenly stepped forward and reached her hands into the "cocoon."

"What are you doing!" Hua Feihua was about to urgently stop her when he saw Liu Wenzhu turn her hands and actually grit her teeth, attempting to tear apart those rays of light.

The delicate woman completely ignored Hua Feihua's dissuasion, focusing entirely on tearing at the "cocoon" with her bare hands. Her bamboo-like pale wrists actually contained boundless divine power. In the stalemate, she truly managed to tear a crack in the cocoon binding Hua Feihua.

Hua Feihua was immediately stunned, shocked by the woman's persistence and strength.

The next moment, veins bulged on Liu Wenzhu's neck as she let out a silent scream. Accompanying her scream, the cocoon binding Hua Feihua shattered into pieces.

With the force that had been enveloping his body gone, Hua Feihua suddenly fell to the ground. His unhealed wounds suddenly struck the ground, causing him such pain that his vision went black.

When light returned to his eyes, he was already being helped to sit up by the woman. Liu Wenzhu was nervously staring with her almond eyes, taking out wound medicine she carried with her and sprinkling it on Hua Feihua's dried blood.

"I never thought Flying Flower Sect would be so strict. Such severe punishment - if this were at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, it would be enough to judge criminals," Liu Wenzhu chattered as she spoke.

"It's nothing. I'm used to this kind of injury," Hua Feihua tried to turn sideways to avoid Liu Wenzhu's medicating hands, but was turned back by her in one motion.

Liu Wenzhu was no ordinary person - she had natural divine strength. So this action not only turned Hua Feihua over but also, in a moment of uncontrolled force, directly tore open the clothing on his chest.

Thus the thin, pale body was left uncovered, with only two white cloth strips at the chest, like white snow covering spring scenery.

Liu Wenzhu's mind immediately went blank. She hastily withdrew her hand as if burned, while Hua Feihua was even more shocked, covering his chest with both hands as red color spread through his skin from chest to behind his ears.

The secret chamber was quiet for a long time before Hua Feihua's deliberately lowered voice finally sounded.

"Miss Liu truly lives up to her name," she said awkwardly. "Delicate willow swaying in the wind."

"I'm... I'm sorry," Liu Wenzhu wished she could find a crack to crawl into. She hurriedly turned her back to Hua Feihua and stood up, not knowing where to put her hands, only clenching them in front of her.

"Miss Liu, this matter is of great importance. Please, Miss Liu, you must keep it secret for me. Absolutely no third person can know," Hua Feihua urged.

However, before she could finish speaking, they heard the sound of wind, and a pink light flashed from outside the door, transforming into a tall figure who immediately said: "Your whereabouts have been discovered - why aren't you fleeing yet!"

While speaking, Ning Fuyi's gaze fell on Hua Feihua's incompletely concealed chest, and her words stopped abruptly.

Looking up to meet both their gazes, all three fell into silence.

Yiyi (T-T): Like this, we absolutely cannot let a fourth person know, right?

Footnotes:

1. **Penglai (蓬莱)** - A legendary mountain from Chinese mythology associated with immortals; in this story appears to be a hostile sect or realm
2. **Jun (钧)** - An ancient Chinese unit of weight, approximately 30 catties or about 15 kilograms
3. **Dianxing (点星)** - Literally "point star"; the name of a town